

and innovation to make the agency more efficient, cost-effective, and thorough.

My suggestion was drawn straight from the principles of this chapter: treat the CFPB as an experiment, identify the elements of the plan that are assumptions rather than facts, and figure out ways to test them. Using these insights, we could build a minimum viable product and have the agency up and running—on a micro scale—long before the official plan was set in motion.

The number one assumption underlying the current plan is that once Americans know they can call the CFPB for help with financial fraud and abuse, there will be a significant volume of citizens who do that. This sounds reasonable, as it is based on market research about the amount of fraud that affects Americans each year. However, despite all that research, it is still an assumption. If the actual call volume differs markedly from that in the plan, it will require significant revision. What if Americans who are subjected to financial abuse don't view themselves as victims and therefore don't seek help? What if they have very different notions of what problems are important? What if they call the agency seeking help for problems that are outside its purview?

Once the agency is up and running with a \$500 million budget and a correspondingly large staff, altering the plan will be expensive and time-consuming, but why wait to get feedback? To start experimenting immediately, the agency could start with the creation of a simple hotline number, using one of the new breed of low-cost and fast setup platforms such as Twilio. With a few hours' work, they could add simple voice prompts, offering callers a menu of financial problems to choose from. In the first version, the prompts could be drawn straight from the existing research. Instead of a caseworker on the line, each prompt could offer the caller useful information about how to solve her or his problem.

Instead of marketing this hotline to the whole country, the agency could run the experiment in a much more limited way: start with a small geographic area, perhaps as small as a few city blocks, and instead of paying for expensive television or radio advertising to let people know about the service, use highly targeted advertising.